SpeechGeek



Season Ten: Winter 2013

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Looking back, 2012 has been an action-packed year. *The Avengers* and *The Dark Knight* muscled their way into theaters and rescued lagging box office sales. Strength and agility also helped U.S. Olympians like Gabby Douglas bring home the gold. And chances are—if you're reading this—the Mayan calendar is being filed away with Y2K in the "Unnecessary End-of-the-Year Worries" box.

While everyone is trying to remember to write the right year, you've got plenty of other things keeping you busy. We're in the full swing of tournament season with district, state, and even national tournaments on the horizon. Your brain is chock full of memorized pieces, tournament planning to-do lists, and polishing pieces after reading ballots. The last thing you need to remember is to go out searching for new literature. That's why we went ahead and published five new pieces in addition to this letter. What a bargain!

Here's hoping that 2013 brings you good fortune, great ballots, and unforgettable performances!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher



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Content

by Wes Tantz

(*While smoking cigarette, Marion should be making subtle touches to her stomach because she is with child—but it shouldn't be obvious.)*

MARION. (*reading from book*) "Poets are always taking the weather so seriously. They are always sticking their emotions in things that have no feelings."

When I first started writing, I used to hail these gaudy beings as proof for why I was the way I was or why I did the things I did. After months of reading, re-reading, and a descent into nihilism, I just realized I was a woman who was too busy rotating on my axis to focus on the planets and shooting stars around me.

(*reading from book)* "All cowardice comes from not loving or not loving well."

Then again, maybe that's what it is. All of these people are too much on their axis, too. Or too busy sucking the life out of anything that remained nameless. You know, I never understood why love was such a holy topic. It's not all that, let me tell you. Let me tell you a story.

I knew a girl once who fell so in love with a boy. She fell and fell and fell and fell so far past the Earth that she spiraled out into the universe. She was carried by all these feelings that seemed warm and comforting, but once thrown into space, they were nothing. She floated with the dust and fell and fell and came to a black hole. There, she was sucked inside, and what did she find? Well, a party! There was booze, there was coke, there were people, and she danced until the stars shook and fell to her feet. There was John Lennon, Albert Einstein, and Ernest Hemingway. And you'll never believe who was hosting the party. Jesus H. Christ himself! Dressed in a pink suit, all Gatsby-like. So cool and so clique, waiting on his Daisy to float on by…(*laughs*). Hmm. You know that's why people never return from black holes. It's one endless party. I mean who'd want to? She sent me a postcard once. It was real nice. Jesus is a handsome looking fellow let me tell you. (*She laughs and continues to smoke.*)

Bruise Ship

by Waylon Brown and Rob Herrick

High school was awful. Seriously. I was always seen as that tall, lanky, and awkward kid who couldn't play basketball. I'm not here to whine about pushing an M&M with my nose down the freshman hall my senior year; that's just surface level stuff. I guess what I'm really trying to say here is that everyone in high school was just so counterfeit. It seemed like they were on stage twenty-four hours a day. Sure, some of them were just doing it for laughs, and they knew it. Honestly though, and I'm not mentioning any names here—um, Gabe—but there were some people who actually believed what they were doing was real life. I guess that's why I'm still having trouble figuring out why I attended my five-year high school reunion...on a cruise ship.

Gabe was the star quarterback, and the rest of the team were his little puppets coming on and off the stage as part of Gabe's little show only when he needed them. A lot of times after he was through using them to help him play a prank on me, or someone else like me, a few of them would feel bad about what they did and sometimes even help me up or apologize. But that was only when he left. I guess that's why I went to the reunion. I had to see just one last time if Gabe was still Gabe and if he was still dominating my first and last girlfriend, Stephanie.

My best friend, Joey, and I still fight over technicalities to this day.

"Dude, you were in *fifth grade,* and you went out for like fifteen minutes!"

Okay, first of all, it was like a half hour; second of all, I saw something in her seven-year-old eyes in that half hour that told me we were different. Everything we did seemed to be original; it seemed like we were together for like...an hour until Gabe beat me up and kissed her within that same half hour. So from sixth grade until now, I have lived my life with one single purpose: to never get a girlfriend, get beat up, and then lose that girlfriend within the same half hour again. I guess stealing her back from Gabe wouldn't be bad either.

Back to the reunion. Now that I'd decided to go, the only thing I could think is, "I've got to look good for this thing. Stephanie's going to be there!" Then it hit me. Me taking all this time to look good would only make me one of "them," the people who take every day as a performance and try to put out some sort of facade that is different from the real them. So I stopped. I put on my wrinkled dress shirt, Dockers shorts, and my old sandals. I reverted back to the real me with the outfit I use to play video games in for ten hours straight. I was all dressed down with someplace to go.

"Who knows?" I said to my unshaven reflection in the mirror. "If we're lucky, it might turn out like *The Love Boat*!"

I gave myself a little wink and a point. Just then, a little voice inside my all-too-pessimistic-but-probably-more-realistic head said, "Yeah, or it could end up like *Jaws*!" I left the house to return to the one place I swore I'd never go again: *high school*; only this time, there was no acting sick and going home. I can't really have my mom come pick me up from the middle of the ocean.

Standing at the loading dock in front of the cruise ship, I see Gabe in the distance putting someone in a headlock, messing their hair up, and laughing while Stephanie stands firmly at attention.

So after about a half hour of really frustrating business, I'm on the boat. The sun is set now, and they're telling me to get to my room and change for dinner. Keeping my old clothes on—still set on not trying to impress anyone—I throw my bags down and head for dinner as is. When I get there, I realize I stick out.

I spot Gabe at the bar flirting with the bartender as Stephanie mingles with some old friends catching up on what's gone on in the last five years like what happened in college and who hooked up with who. You know, the usual. The whole time, they're talking and laughing, Stephanie just stands there acting like she doesn't see what Gabe's doing. My watch tells me that I've been watching these two for about an hour now, but that's not the bad part.

The bad part is that not one person has approached me or even recognized me, and it's starting to freak me out. It's like I know who I am, and I know who they are, but they for sure have no clue who I am. I feel like I just walked onto the set of a messed up version of the *Twilight Zone*—not only am I not dressed up but also nobody recognizes me. They're probably thinking, "Okay, who's the homeless guy trying to get a free dinner?" Even my old principal tried to make the connection, but after a few minutes he shook his head and walked off confused.

It's times like this that I want to give up. It's times like this that I want to have my mom pick me up, bring me home, make me some Kraft macaroni and cheese, and tell me everything is going to be okay. It's times like this that I want someone to stop me from jumping off this boat. It's times like this that I want to grab everyone in this room by the throat and yell, "It's me, you fools! It's me, Tom: the only reason high school was funny for any of you!"

But I don't. Instead, I let a couple of tears fall from my left eye. Then I do what any normal, rational person would do in this situation. I search on the ground like I've lost a contact lens or anything not to look like a homeless guy that broke into a high school reunion's cruise ship for a place to get free dinner and cry. As I search for nothing more than a way to get off this boat, I realize something. I don't need any of these people to validate me. Just as I decide to get up and go, a beautiful and somewhat familiar sound bounces off my eardrums to the sound of,

"Tommy Meyer? Is that you?"

I quickly stand up just long enough to see that it's Stephanie, and as I realize that she is the only person on this godforsaken boat that I have some sort of connection with, I fall right back down to the ground due to the sudden rush of blood to my brain. Thoroughly embarrassed and equally passed out, I fall again. This time into a dream.

I'm watching my Grandpa and me when I was a boy. In the middle of trying to teach me how to hammer a nail straight, he stops, looks at me, and says,

"So, what happened to your eye, Tommy? That Stephanie girl punch you for trying to pinch her butt?"

"No, that Gabe boy punched me for trying to hold that Stephanie girl's hand."

"Well, isn't that *his* girlfriend?"

"No, she said she would by *my* girlfriend at recess."

Before Gabe beat me up that day on the playground, it was like I was just a kid going to school every day. Him beating me up was a clue telling me that I was different. Then I started noticing clues everywhere. On my way home from school, my reflection in store windows told me I was the only one walking alone. Another clue was my mom asking why I didn't have any friends over to play...ever. After all of these clues started adding up, I realized that I *was* different from who I thought I was. Then I placed myself into a new identity: someone that was "different."

"Tommy, I hate to burst your bubble, but do you think Gabe maybe put her up to it?"

"No! She really said we could go out! Really!"

"If you want something—anything—in this world Tommy, I can guarantee you that someone else wants it, too, and that means you have to work harder or it's gone. Good things come to those who wait, but good things are gone to those who are late, late, late, late..."

But I know how hard it is to go back to my initial status, and that's pretty much where I've been stuck ever since. Just then, I woke up to a room full of people surrounding me wondering who the homeless guy is, why did he sneak in, why is he crying, and why did he pass out? I stood up slowly reaching into my pocket and grabbing the note I wrote Stephanie two weeks earlier.

"Here, take this."

I walked off, away from a room full of very confused individuals. I stayed in

my room for the rest of the trip.

When I got home, there was one message on my machine. I hit the play button, and this is what fell upon my unsuspecting ears.

"Hi, Tom. This is Linda from work,"

Dammit.

"Do you want to go out for coffee sometime and maybe get to know each other a little better? Call me back!"

My finger floats over the erase button when I'm struck with another stunning revelation. I don't need Stephanie any more. It's time to look toward the future instead of living my life by what could have been. It's time to move on, and while this Linda girl may or may not be the right step, she's definitely a step in the right direction.